THE GREEN TIGHTROPE

If the government is to realise its grand promises of a green revival, it needs to show unwavering commitment. Pollution and depleting forest cover remain major worries

BY RAHUL NORONHA



PTI

The Union government's environmental report card over the past decade is a patchwork of ambition and oversight. On the one hand, initiatives like the National Adaptation Fund for Climate Change (NAFCC) have seeded nearly 40 climate resilience projects. India's leadership in launching the International Solar Alliance and the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure shows global intent. The plan to generate 50 per cent of all its power using cleaner fuels by 2030, from 44 per cent at present and attain net-zero emissions by 2070 are bold commitments on the climate action front. Yet, amendments to the Forest Conservation Act, 1980, ostensibly to fast-track strategic projects, have environmentalists up in arms. The State of Forest Report's claim of a marginal forest cover increase of 1,540 sq. km—from 21.67 per cent of total area in 2019 to 21.71 per cent in 2021—is overshadowed by the loss of 1,582 sq. km of moderately dense forests. In wildlife, there's cautious optimism. The 2023 tiger census is a roaring success: 3,682 tigers, up by 715 since 2018. The project to reintroduce cheetahs, after a 70-year absence, is slowly finding its feet. But as wildlife numbers climb, their habitats shrink—a paradox that needs resolution.

Urban India's story is written in smog. India's cities rank among the world's most polluted. The persistent spectre of single-use plastics, mounting e-waste and the open sores that are landfills paint a grim picture. The BJP's 2024 manifesto pledges to tackle over 15 environmental issues besides ensuring clean air, scientific waste disposal and river rejuvenation. But promises, like saplings, need more than just planting. They need nurturing and unwavering commitment. ■

EXPERTSPEAK



PRERNA SINGH BINDRA
Ex-member, National Board for Wildlife

"The government must urgently reassess and repeal wildlife, forest and environment laws and policies that have been diluted"

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

TACKLE POLLUTION Indian cities are choking with air pollution, unclean water and pollution arising out of solid waste. Not just metros, even Tier II and III towns have started reporting alarming levels of AQIs. A time